

The Atomium

A monument to the Atomic Age, its nine shining spheres arranged to represent the atoms in a single crystal of iron



Built as the main pavilion for Expo 58, a world's fair held in Brussels in 1958, the Atomium was designed to stand only for the duration of the event. However, its startlingly futuristic design and popularity with the public ensured its survival and its status as one of the most visited attractions in the city. For an exhibit planned to last for only 6 months, the Atomium remains an engineering wonder more than 60 years after it was built.

Emblem of progress

The Atomium is 335 ft (102 m) tall and stands on the Heysel Plateau to the north of Brussels. It was designed by engineer André Waterkeyn (1917–2005) as a symbol of postwar faith

in technological innovation and a vision of a peaceful future guided by scientific knowledge. The structure follows the Atomic Style—popular in the 1950s—that recalls the molecular models of high-school chemistry classes. It takes the shape of nine iron atoms arranged inside a unit cell of an iron crystal magnified 165 billion times. The structure consists of nine spheres, each 60 ft (18 m) in diameter, connected by tubes that are each 10 ft (3 m) wide. These enclose stairs, a central elevator, and escalators that are among the longest in Europe. Only six of the nine spheres are accessible to the public; each has two main floors, containing exhibition halls and other public spaces, and a lower service floor. The top sphere includes a restaurant with panoramic views of Brussels.

